



Shell

△ **Common** spider conch shell

Seashells are the exoskeletons of molluscs, composed primarily of a mineral secretion, as opposed to living cells. Seashells have a long history of use in body ornamentation, and the cowrie, in particular, in currency. Tortoiseshell is of a different substance – the scutes (plates) of the shell used decoratively are of keratin, the protein that also forms fingernails and hair. Tortoiseshell is actually from the Hawksbill turtle, which is now protected. It is a natural plastic, meaning it can be heated and moulded into new shapes.

Specification (seashell)

Chemical name	Calcium carbonate, aragonite		
Formula	CaCO ₃	Colours	White, pink, silver, cream, brown, green, blue, black, yellow
Structure	Amorphous		
Hardness	3–4	SG	2.60–2.78
RI	1.52–1.66	Lustre	Pearly
Locations	Worldwide		



Pink conch | **Rough** | Adult conch shells can grow up to around 30cm (12in) in size. Parts of shells were used by tribes in North America and the Caribbean to make tools.



Episcopal mitre shell | **Rough** | This is the shell of a large sea snail of the species *Mitra mitra*. It is traditionally said to resemble a bishop's headdress.



Shell pitcher | **Set** | This magnificent pitcher from the Argenti Museum in Florence, Italy, is made from nautilus shells. It is also set with pearls, rubies, and turquoise, and is mounted with gilt silver.



Tortoiseshell comb | **Set** | Although it is now prohibited, tortoiseshell was once used as an organic gem. This comb features an ornate tortoiseshell handle with imitation pearls.

Seashells have been used as a form of currency by various cultures throughout history